

Hayden Fuller
Positive Psychology
Happiness Calendar 1
May 01 2026

I found the video very interesting, especially when comparing to this class and my personal life. I've mentioned this in a lot of other things I've written, but I think I see most things very "realistically". I bring this up because I think it helps me with what's explained in the intro, how the modern world is built to make you look outward with envy and inward with disappointment. I can certainly feel somewhat envious of other people I see that are more successful and have more happiness in their lives, but I also see how those people online are far above the average, usually because of some lucky factors that are out of their control. This allows me to see those as possible goals, things to work towards, but certainly not an expectation or a reason to be dissatisfied with myself. In fact, as I do consider myself somewhat bad at coming up with these kinds of creative ideas, I find looking at the lives of others like this and comparing the things they have to my own past and present life to be helpful in reflecting on and finding out what my goals should be, finding what really brings me happiness, and of those things what's realistically achievable with the things I have control over.

I also find gratitude as an evolutionary tool very interesting. This is actually becoming quite similar to another essay I've written, my Eagle Scout essay that claims that the meaning to life, is happiness. This seems somewhat selfish at first glance, especially as many other scouts would, if choosing a prompt like this, write about how helping others is the true meaning of life, but that's just a small part of it. We're evolved to seek out our own happiness, and we're evolved to have empathy and gain happiness from helping others. Similarly, we're evolved to gain gratitude and extra happiness when receiving help from others. I've often heard, like in the video, these referred to as "early forms" of gratitude and happiness, but there's nothing "early" about it, this is still exactly how it works today. We're still ever evolving, and especially in a world where strength and hunting skills are no longer necessary for basic survival, we're socially evolving now using these mechanisms of empathy and gratitude more than ever.

Looking at how having gratitude can refocus your attention to the good things, I think I've done this a lot through life, but usually only when I'm already overall doing well. When times are tough, I can fall into the feedback loop of negativity as well. I think I generally find this very difficult because times are usually tough for a reason, and while having a habit like journaling can certainly help, it's hard to keep good habits up when it's difficult to find 20 minutes to set aside, and if I do, I'd usually rather sleep or eat a meal instead of journaling. That said, through this class it's become more apparent how important having a positive mindset can be, and while that doesn't always make it easy to do, it's certainly easier to at least try to focus on the good parts and be grateful where I can, and it's in always more on my mind to be grateful for the little things.